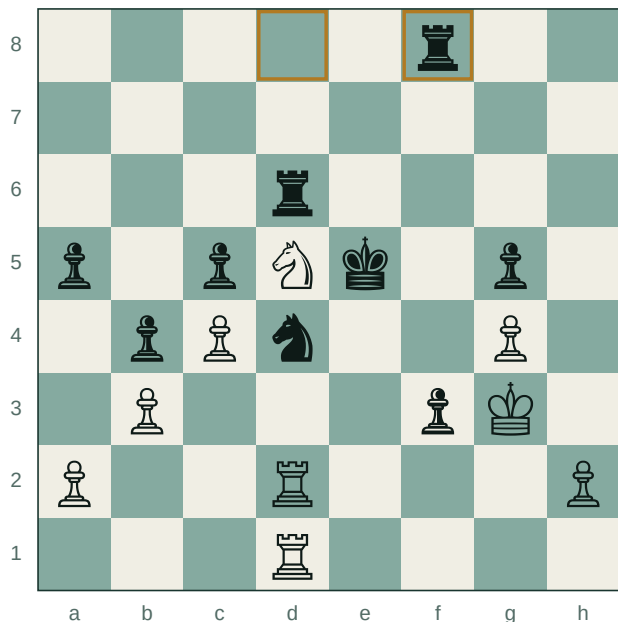


Active defensive resources: White, move 38

Active defensive resources

White to move



Previous move: 37...Rf8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

38. Rxd4 f2 39. R4d3

38.Rxd4 The rook captures the knight on d4. Recorded reply: **38...f2**.

39.R4d3 The rook moves from d4 to d3.

At the end, nominal material is White 18 / Black 15 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from +0 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A defensive puzzle may aim to preserve equality rather than win. Judge success against the threat, not only the final material count.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

The best defense may create a threat, exchange an attacker, or change the geometry of the attack. Identify the opponent's concrete idea before selecting a response.

HOW TO LOOK

Name the threatened move and the conditions it requires. Look for a move that breaks one of those conditions with tempo.

The defending king is on e5. Geometrically undefended: rook on f8. Check for tactical protection.